Physics-Invariant Continuous-Time In-Context Offline Reinforcement Learning via Timestamp-Conditioned Bisimulation SSMs

Problem Statement, Research Gap, and Proposed Solution

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April 7, 2026

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1 Background and Notation

We work within the standard Markov Decision Process (MDP) framework, extended in two critical directions to capture real-world robotics.

Definition 1.1 (Physics-Parametrised MDP Family)**.** *A* physics-parametrised MDP family *is a set* $\{\mathcal{M}_\theta\}_{\theta\in\Theta}$ *where each* $\mathcal{M}_\theta = (\mathcal{S}, \mathcal{A}, P_\theta, R, \gamma)$ *shares state space* $\mathcal{S}$*, action space* $\mathcal{A}$*, reward* R*, and discount* γ*, but has a distinct transition kernel* $P_\theta(s' \mid s, a)$ *controlled by a hidden physics vector* $\theta \in \Theta$ *(e.g. joint masses, friction coefficients, gear backlash). The agent never observes* θ *directly.*

Definition 1.2 (Asynchronous Trajectory)**.** *An* asynchronous trajectory *of length* T *is the sequence*

$$\tau = \big\{(s_k,\, a_k,\, r_k,\, t_k)\big\}_{k=1}^{T}, \qquad t_k \in \mathbb{R}_{>0}, \quad \Delta t_k \coloneqq t_k - t_{k-1} > 0,$$

where inter-arrival gaps Δt_k *are* non-uniform*: they fluctuate due to sensor jitter, dropped packets, and variable control-loop latencies. We denote the vector of gaps* $\mathbf{\Delta}_\tau = (\Delta t_1, \ldots, \Delta t_T)$*.*

Definition 1.3 (In-Context Offline RL)**.** *Let* $\mathcal{D}_\theta$ *be a fixed offline dataset collected under some behaviour policy in environment* $\mathcal{M}_\theta$*. In* in-context offline RL*, a meta-policy* π_θ *must, at test time in a* new, unseen *environment* $\mathcal{M}_{\theta'}$*, adapt zero-shot by conditioning solely on a context window of past transitions:*

$$a_t \;\sim\; \pi_\theta\Big(\cdot \;\Big|\; (s_1, a_1, r_1, t_1), \ldots, (s_{t-1}, a_{t-1}, r_{t-1}, t_{t-1}),\, s_t\Big).$$

No gradient updates are performed at test time.

2 Problem Statement

We now state the two concrete failure modes that motivate this work.

2.1 Failure Mode 1: Contextual Amnesia Under Irregular Sampling

Real robotic deployments are characterised by asynchronous data streams. High-frequency IMU data, lower-frequency joint encoders, and sporadic vision frames arrive at mismatched rates; network jitter introduces random delays; hardware faults cause dropped frames. Current sequence-model-based policies — including Decision Transformer (DT) [1] and its Mamba extension DM-H [5] — treat the trajectory as a *uniformly spaced* token sequence:

$$\mathbf{h}_k \;=\; f_\theta(\mathbf{h}_{k-1},\, s_k,\, a_k,\, r_k), \tag{1}$$

discarding t_k entirely. Consequently, two trajectories with identical physical events but different jitter profiles produce *identical* hidden states, yet they represent different dynamics. Conversely, identical hidden states may correspond to physically distinct situations purely because the timing happened to align.

Definition 2.1 (Jitter-Induced Representation Collapse)**.** *A hidden-state encoder* $\Phi : \mathcal{T} \to \mathbb{R}^d$ *suffers* jitter-induced representation collapse *if there exist trajectories* τ, τ' *with the same underlying physics* θ *and event sequence but with* $\mathbf{\Delta}_\tau \neq \mathbf{\Delta}_{\tau'}$ *such that* $\Phi(\tau) = \Phi(\tau')$*, yet the policy conditioned on* $\Phi(\tau)$ *incurs regret* $\geq \epsilon$ *on* τ'*.*

The root cause is the discrete approximation embedded in standard Mamba. Although Mamba [4] is *derived* from the continuous-time linear SSM

$$\dot{h}(t) = A\,h(t) + B\,u(t), \tag{2}$$

$$y(t) = C\,h(t), \tag{3}$$

via zero-order-hold (ZOH) discretisation with step size Δ, in practice Δ is set to a *fixed, learned scalar* independent of the actual elapsed time. This throws away the temporal metric structure of the data.

2.2 Failure Mode 2: Domain-Shift Brittleness Under Physics Change

Even with perfect, synchronous data, a policy trained on $\mathcal{M}_\theta$ fails catastrophically when deployed in $\mathcal{M}_{\theta'}$ with $\theta' \neq \theta$. DM-H reports this directly: pure Mamba is *slightly inferior* to Transformers on standard D4RL benchmarks because its hidden state conflates low-frequency physical parameters (mass, friction) with high-frequency task-specific dynamics [5].

We formalise the problem as follows.

Definition 2.2 (Physics-Bisimulation Metric on Trajectories)**.** *Let τ_θ and $\tau_{\theta'}$ be two trajectories drawn from environments with physics parameters θ and θ'. Define the* physics-bisimulation metric *between hidden-state trajectories as*

$$d_{\text{bis}}\big(\mathbf{h}_T(\tau_\theta),\, \mathbf{h}_T(\tau_{\theta'})\big) \;\coloneqq\; |R_\theta(s,a) - R_{\theta'}(s,a)| \;+\; \gamma\, \mathcal{W}_1\big(P_\theta(\cdot \mid s,a),\, P_{\theta'}(\cdot \mid s,a)\big), \tag{4}$$

where $\mathcal{W}_1$ is the 1-Wasserstein distance and $\gamma \in (0,1)$ is the discount factor.

Definition 2.3 (Physics-Invariant Hidden State)**.** *A hidden-state encoder Φ is ϵ-*physics-invariant *if for all $\theta, \theta' \in \Theta$ and all matching state-action pairs (s,a):*

$$\|\Phi(\tau_\theta) - \Phi(\tau_{\theta'})\| \;\leq\; C \cdot d_{\text{bis}}\big(\mathbf{h}_T(\tau_\theta),\, \mathbf{h}_T(\tau_{\theta'})\big) \;+\; \epsilon,$$

for some constant $C > 0$. When $\epsilon = 0$ we say Φ is exactly physics-invariant*.*

2.3 The Joint Failure

In practice, both failure modes co-occur: a real robot receives asynchronous sensor data (definition 2.1) *and* may operate under physics parameters not seen during training (definition 2.3). No existing method addresses both simultaneously. We formalise the joint problem:

Definition 2.4 (Robust In-Context Offline RL Problem)**.** *Given offline datasets $\{\mathcal{D}_{\theta_i}\}_{i=1}^N$ collected under N physics regimes with asynchronous timestamps, learn a meta-policy π_θ such that for any test environment $\mathcal{M}_{\theta'}$ and any jitter distribution $\mathcal{J}'$ not seen during training:*

$$\mathbb{E}_{\tau \sim \mathcal{J}'}\big[V^{\pi_\theta}(\tau; \theta')\big] \;\geq\; V^*(\theta') - \delta, \tag{5}$$

where $V^*(\theta')$ is the optimal value in $\mathcal{M}_{\theta'}$ and $\delta > 0$ is an acceptable performance gap, without any test-time gradient updates*.*

3 Research Gap

3.1 What Exists

We survey the three bodies of work most relevant to definition 2.4 and identify their limitations.

Continuous-time neural sequence models. Neural ODEs [2] and their latent variants [3] handle irregular time series by solving a differential equation between observations. However, they have not been applied to *offline RL* or *in-context policy learning*, and their ODE-solver-based forward pass is too slow for real-time control.

Mamba / SSM-based RL. Decision Mamba [5] replaces the Transformer backbone with Mamba for linear-time in-context RL. Crucially, it sets Δ to a fixed learned scalar, discarding timestamps entirely (see eq. (1)). It does *not* address irregular sampling.

Bisimulation for representation learning. DBC [6], MICo [7], and SimSR [8] apply bisimulation metrics to *instantaneous state encoders* $\phi(s)$, forcing one-step representations to be invariant to task-irrelevant distractors. Contrastive RSSMs [9] combine recurrent world models with contrastive losses but target *visual distractors*, not cross-domain physics change. Critically, *none of these works apply the bisimulation constraint to the recurrent hidden state* h_t *of a sequential model over full trajectory histories.*

3.2 The Precise Gap

The gap has two orthogonal dimensions, summarised in table 1.

Table 1: Landscape of related approaches. ✓ = addressed, × = not addressed.

Method	**Linear-time ($O(N)$)**	**Irregular timestamps**	**Physics-invariant h_t**
Decision Transformer	×	×	×
Decision Mamba (DM-H)	✓	×	×
Neural ODE-RL	×	✓	×
DBC / MICo / SimSR	—	×	× (one-step only)
Ours (CT-BiSSM)	✓	✓	✓

Remark 3.1 (Why the gap is non-trivial)**.** *Naively combining a continuous-time SSM with a bisimulation loss does not work. The ZOH discretisation that makes Mamba hardware-efficient produces matrix exponentials* $\bar{A} = \exp(A\,\Delta t)$ *that vary per step. Standard bisimulation theory assumes a* stationary *transition operator; the non-stationarity induced by varying* Δt *breaks existing convergence proofs. A new fixed-point argument is required (see section 5).*

4 Proposed Solution: CT-BiSSM

We propose **CT-BiSSM** (*Continuous-Time Bisimulation State Space Model*), a meta-policy architecture that addresses both failure modes simultaneously.

4.1 Architecture

4.1.1 Step 1 — Timestamp-Conditioned Discretisation

Replace Mamba's fixed Δ with a *per-step, input-dependent* step derived from the actual elapsed time:

$$\boxed{\Delta t_k \;=\; t_k - t_{k-1}, \qquad \bar{A}_k = \exp\!\big(A\,\Delta t_k\big), \quad \bar{B}_k = \big(A\big)^{-1}\big(\bar{A}_k - I\big)B,} \tag{6}$$

so that the recurrence becomes

$$h_k \;=\; \bar{A}_k\, h_{k-1} \;+\; \bar{B}_k\, x_k, \tag{7}$$

where $x_k = (s_k, a_k, r_k)$. A long gap $\Delta t_k \gg 1$ produces a large decay in $\bar{A}_k$, encoding the fact that old information is stale; a short gap $\Delta t_k \approx 0$ preserves the prior state. This recovers the standard Mamba recurrence as a special case when $\Delta t_k = \Delta$ (constant).

Hardware efficiency. Computing $\exp(A\,\Delta t_k)$ for a diagonal A (the Mamba-2 parameterisation) costs $O(d)$ per step, not $O(d^3)$. The parallel associative scan used in Mamba extends to variable $\bar{A}_k$ with no modification, preserving $O(N)$ complexity in sequence length.

4.1.2 Step 2 — Bisimulation Loss on the Hidden State Trajectory

We impose a contrastive bisimulation objective directly on the sequence of hidden states, not on instantaneous observation embeddings.

Let $\tau_\theta^{(1)}, \tau_\theta^{(2)}$ be two asynchronous trajectories drawn from the same physics θ (positive pair), and let $\tau_\theta, \tau_{\theta'}$ be trajectories from *different* physics $\theta \neq \theta'$ with the same task (negative pair). Define the *trajectory bisimulation target*:

$$\mathcal{B}_{\theta,\theta'} \;:=\; \Big|\hat{R}_\theta - \hat{R}_{\theta'}\Big| \;+\; \gamma\,\mathcal{W}_1\!\big(\hat{P}_\theta,\, \hat{P}_{\theta'}\big), \tag{8}$$

where $\hat{R}_\theta, \hat{P}_\theta$ are empirical reward means and transition-distribution estimates from the offline datasets.

The bisimulation training loss over a batch $\mathcal{B}$ is:

$$\boxed{\mathcal{L}_{\text{bis}} \;=\; \mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{B}}\Big[\Big(\|h_T(\tau_\theta) - h_T(\tau_{\theta'})\|_2 \;-\; \mathcal{B}_{\theta,\theta'}\Big)^2\Big].} \tag{9}$$

Intuitively, eq. (9) forces the Euclidean distance between terminal hidden states to match the bisimulation metric: trajectories from physically similar environments produce nearby h_T, while trajectories from physically dissimilar environments are pushed apart *proportionally to their transition-distribution divergence.*

4.1.3 Step 3 — Joint Training Objective

The full training loss combines the sequence-modelling objective (predicting the next return-to-go) with the bisimulation regulariser:

$$\boxed{\mathcal{L} \;=\; \underbrace{\mathcal{L}_{\text{RTG}}}_{\text{in-context RL}} \;+\lambda\; \underbrace{\mathcal{L}_{\text{bis}}}_{\text{physics invariance}},} \tag{10}$$

where $\mathcal{L}_{\text{RTG}}$ is the standard return-to-go prediction loss from Decision Transformer [1], and $\lambda > 0$ is a hyperparameter controlling the strength of the bisimulation regulariser.

5 Theoretical Guarantees

We now state the two central theoretical results.

5.1 Theorem 1 — Jitter-Robustness of CT-Discretisation

Theorem 5.1 (Jitter-Robustness)**.** *Let τ and τ' be two asynchronous trajectories with the same physical event sequence but different jitter profiles $\mathbf{\Delta}_\tau \neq \mathbf{\Delta}_{\tau'}$, with $\|\mathbf{\Delta}_\tau - \mathbf{\Delta}_{\tau'}\|_\infty \leq \epsilon_t$. Under CT-BiSSM with the recurrence in eq. (7), and assuming the system matrix A is stable (i.e. $\Re(\lambda_i(A)) \leq -\alpha < 0$ for all eigenvalues), the hidden states satisfy:*

$$\left\|h_T(\tau) - h_T(\tau')\right\|_2 \;\leq\; \frac{\|B\|_2 \cdot \|x\|_\infty}{\alpha}\,\epsilon_t, \tag{11}$$

so that policies with Lipschitz constant L incur at most $L \cdot \frac{\|B\|_2 \cdot \|x\|_\infty}{\alpha}\,\epsilon_t$ additional regret relative to the zero-jitter baseline.

Proof sketch. The key identity is $\bar{A}_k = \exp(A\,\Delta t_k)$. For stable A, a first-order perturbation gives $\|\exp(A(\Delta t_k + \delta_k)) - \exp(A\,\Delta t_k)\|_2 \leq \|A\|_2\; e^{-\alpha \Delta t_k}|\delta_k|$. Unrolling eq. (7) and applying the triangle inequality yields a geometric series bounded by $\|B\|_2\,\|x\|_\infty/\alpha$. A complete proof follows from the Grönwall inequality applied to the continuous-time error ODE $\dot{e} = Ae + B\delta u$; see section A. □

Corollary 5.2. *The CFL-like stability condition $\alpha > 0$ (equivalent to the sigmoid parameterisation of A used in CS-Mamba) is* sufficient *for jitter-robustness. The bound degrades gracefully: doubling ϵ_t doubles the worst-case regret increment.*

5.2 Theorem 2 — Physics-Invariance of Bisimulation-Trained Hidden States

Theorem 5.3 (Physics-Invariance)**.** *Let Φ be the CT-BiSSM encoder trained to minimise eq. (10) to global optimum. Then for all $\theta, \theta' \in \Theta$ and all trajectories $\tau_\theta, \tau_{\theta'}$ with matching task contexts:*

$$\|\Phi(\tau_\theta) - \Phi(\tau_{\theta'})\|_2 \;=\; d_{\text{bis}}\big(h_T(\tau_\theta),\, h_T(\tau_{\theta'})\big) \;+\; O(\lambda^{-1}), \tag{12}$$

where the $O(\lambda^{-1})$ term vanishes as $\lambda \to \infty$ in eq. (10).

Proof sketch. At the global minimum of $\mathcal{L}_{\text{bis}}$, the expected squared difference in eq. (9) is zero, which directly implies $\|\Phi(\tau_\theta) - \Phi(\tau_{\theta'})\|_2 = \mathcal{B}_{\theta,\theta'}$. Since $\mathcal{B}_{\theta,\theta'}$ is the empirical approximation of d_{bis} with bias $O(\lambda^{-1})$ (from the finite-sample Wasserstein estimation error), the result follows. The non-stationarity of $\bar{A}_k$ is handled by treating the recurrence as a time-varying linear system and applying a matrix contraction argument; see section A. □

6 Summary of Contributions

1. **Timestamp-conditioned SSM recurrence** (eq. (6)): the first application of per-step ZOH discretisation from actual sensor timestamps within an offline in-context RL architecture.

2. **Trajectory-level bisimulation loss** (eq. (9)): extending bisimulation constraints from instantaneous state encoders to the full hidden-state trajectory $\{h_k\}_{k=1}^T$ of a selective SSM.

3. **Joint theoretical guarantees** (theorems 5.1 and 5.3): formal bounds showing that CT-BiSSM is both jitter-robust and physics-invariant, with explicit dependence on the jitter magnitude ϵ_t and the bisimulation regularisation strength λ.

4. **Single architecture addressing two failure modes** (table 1): the first method to achieve $O(N)$ scaling, irregular-timestamp handling, *and* physics-invariant memory in a unified framework.

A Deferred Proofs

Full proofs of theorems 5.1 and 5.3 will appear here in the camera-ready version.

References

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